FIONAASHTONEDIT

Travel Radio Australia and we are here at the International Golf Travel Market in Cannes in France and I'm very lucky to be able to catch up with the show director Fiona Ashton. Fiona welcome to the program. Thanks very much it's good to be here.

Now Fiona this is such an iconic show for the golf industry isn't it? It happens every year here in Cannes around October and and people from all over the world come here. Can you tell us a bit about this show and then we'll with read exhibitions and then we'll go on to others. Yeah sure so we've been running it since 1998 and actually it's not always in Cannes, it was in Cannes this year and last year but generally we move to a different location every year.

Next year we're moving to Bellac but it has run all around the world particularly in Europe so we've been running since 98 and next year will be our 30th edition so we'll be celebrating a big landmark event then. The exhibition is made up of exhibitors from tourism boards, from golf courses, from around the world and from DMC's and they come here to meet with golf tour operators and they are also international so we've got 57 countries represented here and rather than an exhibition it's more of a one-to-one meetings event so everyone has a really full diary of up to around 40 meetings over three days. There's lots of networking events too, we have an opening party, a closing party they're always quite special and then we have a golf day preceding the show on the Monday so we run that across three or four golf courses around 300 people take part and that's hotly contested and it's a really good day.

And the one you had here telling me about the course they were raving about the course here. Yeah there was three really good courses this year, one's Terre Blanche, one's Grand Vastide and one is Opie A Valbonne so we're very grateful to them for they were hosting the event for us. A bit about your background Fiona, how did you come to be working on these fabulous shows all around the world? So at the moment I work on just IGTM so this is my baby now, this is what I do.

I have worked on World Travel Market in London in the past and I've also worked on Arabian Travel Market, I did around 13 years on Arabian so they're really exciting events. I've always worked in exhibitions so for the last nearly 25 years I've been in exhibitions and always with a marketing background so I've now moved into event management. IGTM was the first event I went to when I came to read so that's 14 years ago and I worked on the 2012, 2013 and 2014 we were in Costa Dorada, we were in Lake Como and we were in Villamura in Portugal so three really good golfing destinations and it's always great to hold the event somewhere where the golf's really good too.

So I've been in the events industry for a long time and golf for the last 14 years. Now read exhibitions you've got your own stand here of course and I've been looking on the map. World Travel Market is just one of these fabulous events and I will be there next month in London for

that at the Excel.

Tell us about some of the other World Travel Market events around the world. So we have the event I just mentioned Arabian Travel Market in Dubai so that's been running around 30 years as well so that's a really large event. It's actually the one with the most footfall believe it or not what we call the highest density show of all our travel markets.

We've got one in Sao Paulo in Brazil in the spring. We've also got one in South Africa. We've just launched WTM spotlight which is brand new type of event and that just looks at some smaller markets so we've got one in Saudi that happened last month and we've got one in India that's taking place next spring so we're popping up all over the world now so it's nice to have a footprint in so many different places.

I can highly recommend the World Travel Market if you're in the travel industry in any capacity whether it's you own a hotel or you're a journalist or you're just just interested in the travel world or travel industry it really is the place because it's so big. WTM is fantastic. Yeah I absolutely love going there I'm going to be there myself this year as an exhibitor and we're actually looking after a mini golf activation so we're going to have a lot of fun there I think in the next few days.

How can people find out more online and how can they book into these events whether they're trade or visitors or whatever? IGTM the event I described at the beginning is very much the one-to-one meetings event but this year we launched IGTM discovery so this is open to the golf trade clothing companies so the apparel that you might sell in a pro shop we have accessories we have technologies so it's a really good place for the golf courses to come and visit. The golf course is exhibiting over IGTM. IGTM discovery is also really important new edition so in order to find out about it just go to the website www.igtmarket.com that's it www.igtmarket.com. That's great and thanks so much for having Travel Radio Australia here it's been so wonderful meeting all of your partners and we've got tons of interviews from this event and we're really looking forward to WTM Fiona Ashton thanks so much for being on the program.

Thanks very much I'll see you at WTM